

2-2 Final Project Part I Milestone One: Self-Assessment

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Abstract

This milestone will summarize my StrengthsFinder® results and compare these results with the cognitive factors associated with leadership effectiveness. I will provide three examples and explain how my leadership strengths and traits contribute to the effectiveness of business operations at Barnett Harley-Davidson where I am currently the inventory supervisor and director of photography.

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According the author of our textbook, leadership is the ability to inspire confidence and support among the people who are needed to achieve organizational goals (DuBrin, 2015).

Leadership is different from management because leaders don't always have authority or serve an executive function like a manager. Instead, leaders inspire and help the team accomplish goals. The textbook outlines several types of leaders in organizations:

- The Figurehead
- The Spokesperson
- The Negotiator
- The Coach
- The Team Player
- The Technical Guy

Each type of leader must use social skills to acquire followers and build networks. Along with an entrepreneurial spirit and talent, a leader strives to ensure that organizational goals are met (DuBrin, 2015).

Summary of Results

When I began the StrengthsFinder® assessment, I was not sure what to expect of the outcome. Generally, I am not a fan of personality tests nor do I give any credence to the results of such activities. Yet after completing the reading in our textbook and being presented with evidence-based proof that some traits are indeed shared by the most influential leaders I have come to accept that these tests serve a valuable purpose.

According to the results of the assessment, I possess the following top three traits:

- Learner

- Achiever
- Restorative

As a learner, I must refine how I receive and process new information, designate myself as an early adopter of technology, honor my desire to learn, and be a catalyst for change. The achievement trait ensures that I strive to overcome challenges and enlist the help of focused individuals to tackle difficult tasks. Restoratives seek out roles where they are paid to solve problems (Gallup, 2016).

I can definitely identify with the learner and achiever traits. After all, I am continuing my education and strive to achieve my goals. Being a lifetime learner is extremely important to me and I think that education is the key to achieve my short and long term goals. I am not surprised that I was also designated as a restorative person because I often have to clean up other people's messes and fixing problems others have created. I think this is not a role that I favor or even seek out, but in the business world this is a task that I have grown to enjoy this task because it earns me recognition and provides a path towards advancement.

Analysis of Cognitive Factors and Leadership

In addition to exhibiting these traits, strong leaders also wish to control resources. This drive to manage manifests itself in assertiveness and being proactive with regards to affecting environmental changes. Strong leaders also possess certain cognitive abilities such as specialized knowledge in a specific industry and creativity (DuBrin, 2015). These traits have no benefit if one does not also possess a strong ability to perceive how others are feeling and have the social skills necessary to gain a loyal following.

Emotional intelligence is a vital key to effective leadership. Not only does one need the traits and cognition of a leader, but also a strong connection with subordinates that allows for

effective communication and trust. Evelyn Williams uses this analogy to describe whether leaders are born or trained: “I think leadership is a combination of nature and nurture. Just as some musicians have a special talent for playing instruments, some people seem to be born with leadership abilities” (DuBrin, 2015).

The trait that best exemplifies the cognitive abilities associated with leadership is the ability to learn. A strong leader must refine how they learn. If one learns best by teaching, you must seek out opportunities to instruct others. If you learn best through reflection, carve out this quiet time. The discipline and focus required to be a strong and effective leader can be gained through embracing the ability to learn and discover new ways to approach specific tasks.

Application of Examples

My role at Barnett Harley provides me with the opportunity to utilize these three traits quite often. To reiterate, I am the inventory manager and director of photography at the world’s largest Harley-Davidson dealership. My responsibilities include maintaining a database of all of our current and past inventory with detailed information regarding financial reporting and specific details about individual units in inventory. I also create imagery used for marketing and listing inventory online through several ecommerce platforms.

I took advantage of my ability to learn when I started at Barnett Harley and quickly mastered the software applications used for internal control. I quickly adopted the technology we use on a daily basis to manage our massive inventory of over 800 units and developed new ways to leverage that convenience to streamline the process. When I found ways to streamline business operations in a way that would increase productivity and efficiency, I was the catalyst for change.

Working for the largest dealership in the world sometimes creates interesting and unique challenges. I am often overwhelmed with the scope of projects and the sheer volume of business

we conduct on the daily. This is where the achievement trait allows me to create goals and enlist the help of focused and talented individuals. As with any massive endeavor, I continuously take large problems and tasks and break them into smaller, more manageable pieces. As I complete each step on my path towards the larger goal, I take time to celebrate my accomplishments and plan the best way to move forward towards the final goal making sure to review my progress and think critically about the efficiency of my methods and always making adjustments where necessary.

The restorative role is without a doubt the most critical function I serve. Not a day goes by that I am not identifying and addressing issues created by individuals that either did not possess the skills needed to complete the task they attempted or simply did not perform to the best of their abilities. For example, there are sometimes issues with the general ledger that I come across and I must reconcile discrepancies and conduct regular audits to ensure that our accounting is free of errors. I also act as an internal control to prevent unethical or in some cases criminal activities. In fact, in just six months I have been involved with three separate audits that resulted in the termination of several low level employees that were stealing.

References

DuBrin, A. J. (2015). *Leadership: Research Findings, Practice, and Skills, 8th Edition*. Cengage Learning.

Gallup. (2016). *YOUR STRENGTHSFINDER RESULTS*. Retrieved from Gallup Strengths Center online: <https://www.gallupstrengthscenter.com/Dashboard>